

Doyen of the game: Vikram Rathour reckons Rahul Dravid is the best coach he has worked with to date. K. R. DEEPAK

muscular bench strength in Indian cricket. The team boasts a solid lineup with emerging talents. Shubman Gill, for instance, has made his mark, and Dhruv Jurel played an extraordinary innings in the last Test match against England. As the next generation steps in, the future looks even brighter. A lot of credit goes to how domestic cricket is played in India, producing players, who are ready to step into international cricket.

Do you think bowlers who are poor with the bat are a thing of the past? We have seen the emergence of R. Ashwin as a Test batter. What sort of work went behind it?

One of the key areas I worked on, and I would love to take credit for it, is lower-order batting. I worked extensively with lower-order batsmen. I would give them more batting practice. It helped. We are contributing more in the lower order now than before. Ashwin was always a good batter. He had Test hundreds before I joined the team as batting coach. He loves to discuss a lot of cricket. There was a slump and he worked on specific areas. He rediscovered himself as a Test batter.

What are your impressions of Virat Kohli as a player and a captain?

Virat is the best batsman of this generation in all three formats. He is a phenomenal player with a great work ethic. Virat wants to do well every time he bats, wanting to win every game he plays. That is his best quality.

He has a fantastic ability to adapt. He can change his game according to the situation. He plays all three formats differently. As a captain, his trait is to play fearlessly. He taught the team to stand up to the big teams. He puts the opposition under pressure with his aggression as a leader. He introduced the concept of fitness in Indian cricket and changed the team's mindset.



How is Rohit as a player and a captain?

He is exceptional. I call him a player's captain. I haven't seen anyone who spares so much time for the players. He backs his players. The players also know that he will be there to support them if things go wrong. He is part of every meeting. He also wants to sit in the batter's and bowlers' meetings. He wants to know everything discussed to implement it in the field. Tactically, he is marvellous. He does certain things that will surprise you. You wonder as to why this guy is bowling at this juncture and why this guy is fielding in a particular position. Eventually, it turns out that Rohit is spot on. He reads the game well.

Your biggest challenge would have come in Australia, when India played with almost a B team, came back strongly, and won an epic series.

We prepared well for that series. We were there early; we had some practice sessions. Those were COVID times, and we were in isolation. We had an exclusive practice area, which gave us an excellent opportunity to work and prepare well. We were in a perfect position in the first Test, and the 36 all-out happened. It was a freak session. The message in the group was simple: There's nothing

wrong with what we did. Let's not start overthinking and overanalysing. We did not panic. It turned out to be one of the best series ever.

Coming back to the T20 World Cup, did playing on those poor pitches in the USA help before the Super 8 stage?

It was too challenging. Those are not the pitches on which you should be playing T20 cricket, but they helped us. As a team, you want some tight games. One of the areas we needed to get better at was batting first. We were always an excellent team chasing. It was good to see that we could put up challenging totals.

Were you stern as a batting coach?

I don't believe in that philosophy because mistakes are part of the journey and process. Keep moving forward, learning from your mistakes, and practising your strengths or areas for improvement. You will be fine if you keep preparing well and practising those things sincerely.

What did you learn from Ravi Shastri during his term as head coach?

Great man management skills. He doesn't let a poor session or a match affect him too much. After the 36 all